

◀ M36 MUSETTE BAG

Date 1936

Origin US

Material Canvas

This versatile mini-haversack held ammunition, rations, and personal effects. The rope was included in case the soldier needed to free himself from a tree or building on landing.

Attachment straps

Rope 10m (33ft) in length

Standard issue raincoat folded under flap

▼ FG42 AUTOMATIC RIFLE

Date 1943

Origin Germany

Weight 4.53kg (10lb)

Barrel 50.2cm (19¾in)

Calibre 7.9mm

The FG42 was a fully automatic weapon designed to provide long-range firepower to paratroopers on the ground. It pioneered a "straight-line" butt-to-muzzle layout and employed a gas-operated firing mechanism.

Folding sight

Bipod legs

Slanting pistol grip

◀ TYPE T5 PARACHUTE

Date c.1940

Origin US

Material Silk (later rayon)

The T5 was the standard parachute used by the US Army throughout World War II. Static lines attached to the plane automatically deployed the parachute as the paratrooper jumped from the aircraft.

Pull-out panel covering main parachute

Leather washers form grip

Recurved quillons

▶ MK3 FIGHTING KNIFE

Date 1943

Origin US

Weight 240g (8½oz)

Length 29.5cm (11½in)

Based partly on the British Fairbairn-Sykes commando knife, the Mk3 was intended for hand-to-hand combat. Paratroopers strapped the knife on to their lower leg for ease of access.

Metal butt stock

Diamond-section blade

▶ AIRBORNE GRAVITY KNIFE

Date 1937

Origin Germany

Weight 350g (12½oz)

Length 25.3cm (10in)

Issued to German paratroopers, this knife could be opened with one hand. When the operating lever was opened, the blade fell forwards due to gravity. It was intended primarily to help the soldier free himself from a tangled parachute harness.

Spike

▶ BSA FOLDING BICYCLE

Date 1943

Origin UK

Weight (Frame) 2kg (4½lb)

The armed forces had used folding bicycles extensively during World War I, but this lightweight model was designed especially for commandos and airborne forces, to provide them some much-needed mobility.

Rear red lens light

Sprocket with Birmingham Small Arms (BSA) logo